

Harsha Vemulapalli

Design executive with 25+ years of experience, 16 of them leading and scaling design organizations with director-level reports. I build AI-native design and research practices, and the quality systems that let distributed teams ship at a consistently high bar, across enterprise platforms, commerce, connected vehicles, and regulated public health. Currently leading a 70-person UX, research, and content strategy organization at Siemens across seven countries.

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Experience

Global Director, Experience Design & Research

Siemens · April 2023 – Present

Grew and lead a global UX, research, and content strategy organization from 5 to 70 people across seven countries, within a complex B2B ecosystem spanning industrial automation and AI-driven customer experiences.

PLATFORM & COMMERCE

- Own and govern the One Siemens design system. Put the first- and third-party marketplace at the center of Siemens' digital experience and integrated the marketing site and business-unit selling channels around it: a single explorable catalog of hundreds of thousands of Siemens and third-party products, across 100K+ pages, consolidating 150+ sites into one
- Own the design of the marketing and purchase funnels, partnering with Product and Engineering to improve usability and conversion through experimentation and data-informed iteration
- Set governance for 3,000+ internal creators, and organized the catalog so customers navigate by their own needs rather than Siemens' org structure

AI-NATIVE PRACTICE

- Led design and research for an AI-powered product finder that increased conversion 23% and engagement 28%
- Led strategy and training for an AI research agent on Microsoft Copilot that unified research repositories and lets stakeholders query insights in natural language, increasing data utilization 20% and cutting time-to-insight 34%

ORGANIZATION

- Manage managers (4 direct reports) and partner as a peer to Product and Engineering on sprint planning, backlog priorities, and technical tradeoffs
- Built a career-growth tool that combines industry best-practice frameworks with self- and manager-scoring, helping every level of the team find and develop the skills for the roles they aspire to

Senior Manager UX, Smart Vehicle

Amazon · September 2022 – January 2023

Directed design and research for Amazon's next-gen in-vehicle platform, spanning embedded commerce, media, and personalization.

- Led a 13-person team (3 direct reports) across UX design, research, conversational design, and visual design in Seattle, San Francisco, and Detroit
- Designed vehicle-specific commerce and monetization features, balancing safety, usability, and business impact within hardware-freeze timelines
- Introduced leaner design processes that increased collaboration and cut delivery timelines 12%

Sr. Design Director

VMware · April 2021 – September 2022

Led design, research, and experience strategy for mission-critical enterprise tools through VMware's Sub-to-SaaS transformation, a company-level inflection point.

- Modernized the CPQ (configure-price-quote) platform, cutting time-on-task 30% and accelerating deal velocity across 35,000+ users, in direct partnership with Product and Engineering
- Re-platformed digital systems for a post-COVID hybrid workforce while holding 75%+ CSAT and reducing support load 20%

- Built a 75-person distributed team (9 direct reports) across UX strategy, design, research, content design, and design operations in Palo Alto, Sofia, and Bangalore
 - Designed a centralized experience scorecard and measurement framework adopted company-wide
 - Operated as player/coach, contributing directly to critical design work while mentoring senior ICs and scaling leadership capacity
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Director, Digital Brand, UX and Research

CARFAX · October 2019 – April 2021

Led UX, brand, and research across consumer touchpoints for one of the most recognized names in automotive.

- Led an end-to-end product redesign that delivered a 7% conversion lift and a 26% reduction in development churn
 - Elevated the brand across consumer touchpoints, from mobile apps to dealer products, with a repeatable design process and research cadence
 - Led a 30-person team (3 direct reports) across UX design, research, graphic design, and design operations
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Head of Design, North America

Robert Bosch, LLC · October 2016 – October 2019

Joined as employee zero and built Bosch's North American internal design consultancy into a ~120-person practice (5 direct reports, 90 indirect).

- Ran an internal design agency and a design-thinking incubator that took non-design teams from early concept to launched products with startup-level agility
 - Led research and design of an AI/ML-powered radio and infotainment system, trading off physical controls and screen to lower glance times and improve customer sentiment while cutting hardware cost
 - Designed connected-vehicle and consumer services, including fleet maintenance, community and parking apps, and keyless access, plus B2C e-commerce for Power Tools
 - Drove service design initiatives that saved \$6M while strengthening key industry partnerships
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User Experience Manager

General Motors · September 2014 – October 2016

Led the design of the full owner journey across seven global brands, from brand sites through ownership and trade-in.

- Led the design of brand websites, the vehicle configurator, purchase and finance flows, OnStar onboarding, and ownership through maintenance and trade-in
 - Set purchase and finance interaction patterns adopted across Chevrolet, Cadillac, Buick, GMC, Opel, Vauxhall, and OnStar
 - Built a unified, pattern-driven design system that launched seven mobile apps in 23 languages within one year, with OnStar, CarPlay, and Android Auto integration
 - Created a new in-app services revenue stream exceeding \$1M in its first year
 - Scaled and led a 140-person multidisciplinary team across research, UX, visual design, and front-end development in Detroit and Austin
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Design Manager

Air Mobility Command · May 2013 – September 2014

Led consulting teams delivering mission-critical planning and decision-support systems for U.S. Air Force operations.

- Directed end-to-end design for high-urgency planning tools supporting 1,200+ daily missions, generating \$2M+ in operational savings
 - Established command-wide human interaction design guidelines based on research-driven principles
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User Experience and Analytics Manager

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention · December 2010 – May 2013

Led UX, research, and analytics for the National Center for HIV/AIDS, Viral Hepatitis, STD, and TB Prevention: 18+ sites and tools with 70M+ page views a year.

- Redesigned HIVTest.org as the center's first responsive mobile site, under HIPAA and Section 508, lifting HIV testing conversion 70%
- Launched the center's first mobile app
- Built the enterprise measurement framework used for data-driven experience decisions at national scale

Earlier experience

Interaction Designer

Blackbaud · Nov 2007 – Dec 2010

Designer

SoftSys, LLC · May 1999 – Jul 2001

Product Manager & Design Engineer

Morris Digitalworks · Feb 2004 – Oct 2007

Research Analyst

Mirant, LLC · Aug 2001 – Oct 2003

Skills

Design org leadership & scaling

Leading large, distributed design orgs (70+ people, director-level reports, 16 years at this scale) · Managing managers · Org design & succession · Player/coach leadership · Culture & mentoring · Partnership with Product & Engineering · Executive alignment · Leading through inflection points

Design systems & quality

Design system ownership at enterprise scale (100K+ pages, 150+ sites consolidated, 3,000+ creators) · Tokens, components & governance · Definitions of done · Launch review frameworks · Accessibility & privacy standards

Research & craft

UX research & research operations · Usability testing · Measurement frameworks · Behavioral science · Interaction & visual design · Data visualization · Web, native mobile & in-vehicle HMI

AI-native design practice

Agentic & conversational UX · LLM integration & prompt design · Validation frameworks for LLM outputs · AI tooling adoption & workflow redesign · Building org-wide AI fluency · AI-assisted prototyping (Figma Make)

Growth, commerce & conversion

Marketing & purchase funnel design · Marketplace & e-commerce UX · Vehicle configurators · Experimentation (A/B, multivariate) · Data-informed iteration · Enterprise workflows (CPQ)

Tools

Figma · FigJam · Figma Make · Microsoft Copilot · Miro · Dovetail · UserTesting · Jira · Notion · Adobe CC · HTML/CSS

Thought leadership

Leading Teams through AI

Panel speaker, UX Researchers' Guild, Dec 2025

Creating a Human-Centered Company

AV18 Autonomous Vehicle Conference, 2018

Gaming & Mobile for Public Health

CDC NPIN Health Webcast, 2013

IDC MarketScape: Digital B2B Ecosystems and Marketplaces

Featured expert, IDC, Sept 2025

Designing the Human Experience

Automotive Cockpit HMI, 2018

Usability in Public Health

National HIV Prevention Conference, 2011

Forrester: Leveraging AI for E-commerce in B2B Organizations

Featured expert, Forrester, 2025

Five Agile Challenges for Distributed Teams

AgileConnection/TechWell, 2014

Education & certifications

Bachelor of Science, Information Technology

American InterContinental University, 2001

Behavioral Design

Irrational Labs, 2024

Decision by Design

Farnam Street, 2025

UX Research certificate

University of Denver, 2016

Google AI Essentials

Google, 2025

Certified Agile Product Owner & Scrum Master

Scrum Alliance, 2009